

A Guide to Writing Personal Essays for Undergraduate Applications
Prepared by Connor Williams, Yale College Writing Center
(Last Revised 4/19/18)

Overview:

Crafting the personal essay may be the most confusing or difficult part of applying to colleges and universities. After spending many years dedicated towards academic and extracurricular excellence, students are asked to suddenly write about themselves in some sort of derivative fashion: a time your values were tested, a problem you would like to solve, or some part of your identity, and all in 650 words or less. This guide is intended to help students with strategies for how to think about the personal essay, how to outline a topic, and how to write the final product.

The Personal Essay:

Oftentimes, the personal essay can seem daunting because students feel like they need to summarize their application in some neat fashion or find a way to brag about their accomplishments without seeming to be bragging. This is a misconception of the purpose of the personal essay. Rather than thinking of the essay as the last chance to “explain” your application, think of it as the first (and best) chance to tell the university about yourself as a person: the kind of personality, character, and passions that you’ll bring with you if admitted.

This last point might be best illustrated by looking at the admissions process from a distance. The institutions you’re applying to already have a good amount of information that speaks to your strengths as a student: your grades, your transcript, your standardized test scores, your school profile(s), and letters of recommendation. All of these help tell about your abilities as a student. What the university or college is missing is a picture of your interests and motivations in general, and this is why the personal essay exists.

To use Yale as a case study: in 2018 Yale received approximately 35,000 applications for an admitted class of about 2,200. Approximately 200 or 300 of those applying students will be admitted “automatically,” because they’re truly exceptional at something: they’re the best cello player in their nation, they’ve proved mathematical theorems, they already have a successful start-up company, etc. The other 34,800 applicants, who by-and-large all have similarly high grades and abilities, will largely have their admissions decision made based on how they present themselves as unique candidates who will bring something to campus that sets themselves apart from a similar student with similar grades. This is where the personal essay can have a large role.

Ultimately, colleges are trying to choose students not only for their abilities as intellectuals, but also for how they will use those abilities to have an impact on the campus life and culture—how they’ll contribute to their classes, what interests they’re likely to pursue, or/and what impact they’ll have on extra-curricular life. As you may know, the full costs of educating a student at most universities goes beyond even what

they charge for full tuition. This means that in a sense, colleges are subsidizing all students' educations. You want your application to convince a college that you'll contribute more to the university climate and culture—in your own particular ways—than another peer would who has similar grades and scores. Of course, you do this not by degrading that peer, but rather by highlighting what makes you unique.

Writing the Personal Essay:

Students can prepare to write the personal essay in several ways. In most every prompt on both the Common Application and the Coalition Application, they're really asking you to reflect on what might be called your "personal/academic biography"—or how and why you have become the person and student that you are. So in brainstorming, you might want to think about answering the following questions:

- What skills have made me successful in meeting my goals?*
- What does somebody need to know about me to "get" who I am?*
- What experiences have been essential in making me into the person I am today?*
- What parts of public discourse do I do better than most of my peers? (Answers to this might be things like "I'm good at having difficult conversations," "I'm never content until a project is done," or "I'm really good at thinking creatively to solve problems.")*

These answers can help to distill your experiences into a topic that you can appropriately consider in 650 words. It's generally better to give a deeper consideration of one or two facets of your personality, goals, or experiences than it is to give a cursory examination of too many.

Five Things to Keep in Mind When Writing an Application Essay

While every personal essay should be unique to the person writing it, there are some strategies that have been proven to work, and general things to remember. As you write your essay, you might want to keep in mind the following tips:

--Focus on Character and/or Goals, not Past Accomplishments:

As was discussed earlier, the personal statement should be grounded in articulating your character or goals, and not simply your accomplishments. Any past awards or high marks you have earned have already shown up on your transcript and on other points of your application. So simply listing them again adds little to your profile. Instead, strive to write about who you've become or what your goals are for the future. To the extent that you do find yourself wanting to write about an accomplishment, make sure to frame it in terms of how you achieved it, and what it has meant to you since you achieved it. Watch out for long descriptions of the award/accomplishment itself.

--It's all about you:

As this is the best chance for a college or university to get to know you, make sure that you're actually writing about yourself. It can be tempting to write about someone who inspired you, or to whom you owe much for your development—but ultimately, those people are not applying to college. So an essay all about how brave somebody else was, or how much hard work they've done to help you, ultimately doesn't tell the admissions officers anything about you as the candidate. To be sure—essays that speak of a lesson you learned from another, or discussing how a relationship has shaped your life, can be powerful. But make sure that you are making the focus on you, and how your life has been impacted by this relationship.

--There is (Almost) Never a Need to Apologize:

Personal essays shouldn't be the places where you seek to "make up" for some mistake of your past. Admissions officers are people, too, and they've all made their share of errors in their lives. To the extent that colleges or universities do want information on past misdeeds—such as criminal convictions—there will traditionally be another part of the application where they ask for an explanation. So beyond anything in that realm, you shouldn't feel the need to bring up anything that you don't want to. The personal statement especially should **not** be the place where you write about things like a bad grade or test score (unless it's part of a specific narrative about your progress from that point). In all scenarios, always set your experiences as positive ones that ultimately enriched your development—not as deficiencies you want to apologize for.

--You're More Unique Than You Think:

Students sometimes think that their stories aren't unique enough to set them apart from their peers, and that if they haven't already achieved some incredible success then they are by default "average." In almost every case, this is false: every student has some sort of skill set or personal perspective that will appeal to a college or university, provided that student articulates it well. So whether you're worried that you're "just another suburban kid" or "just another foreign student," that is only the case if you project it as such. Generally speaking, as long as you're writing honestly about your own personal development or goals, they're bound to be more unique than you may think.

--Grab your reader with the first sentence, and the first paragraph:

Any ethical admissions officer will read your entire essay—and often a committee will. But readers start to form their judgments from the first word. So an effective essay will use compelling language and narrative to start off. If writing about a time that your values were tested, don't begin with "One time that my values were tested was..." Instead, try to grab the reader's attention with something unusual. Quirky or compelling openings along the lines of "I never thought a trip to a museum would cause an ethical dilemma," or "My values have always rested upon two things: civic duty and homemade soup" can make a reader interested in the essay from the first sentence.

Final Thoughts:

The personal essay is the most prominent place in an application where you get to explain who you are, as a person, to an admissions committee. Take courage knowing you that

you are already a unique and interesting person—the seventeen-or-so years of life you’ve had to this point have given you a perspective and academic practice that is specific to yourself. The best essays are those that celebrate that perspective and practice, in whatever unique way you choose. The least successful, on the other hand, are often ones that seek to project some inauthentic persona because it’s what you or a counselor *thinks* the institution wants to hear.

So ultimately, write about what you know the best—and in this case, that’s yourself.